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Introduction

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This book addresses the prospects of imperial power from above, emerging powers from the middle and nascent popular counter-powers from below. The relative economic decline of the United States, Europe and Japan is often linked to the rise of an 'emerging' bloc comprising Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa (BRICS). But the latter regularly demand 'a seat at the table' in a process that some term 'antagonistic cooperation'. That means, in practice, that in areas ranging from world finance to climate change to super-exploitative relations with the periphery and even to soccer, the bloc aims not to overturn tables at the proverbial temple, but to collaborate in holding them up. Consider some recent evidence:

- After funding the International Monetary Fund (IMF) with US$75 billion in 2012, in the following year there were two meetings of BRICS leaders (in Durban and St. Petersburg) which pronounced growing dissatisfaction with the Bretton Woods Institutions.
- The BRICS' stated intention to create a New Development Bank with capital of US$50 billion, and an IMF-style Contingent Reserve Arrangement with US$100 billion, was accomplished in 2014 at the Fortaleza summit, but ultimately, given the role of neoliberal finance ministers in their conceptualisation, these were celebrated in Washington as complementary to, not competitive with, the existing multilateral financial power structure.
- A Brazilian directs the World Trade Organisation and, based on a more aggressive policy of liberalisation, tries to break persistent blockages between